“secularism”. Even Iqbal, the philosopher of Partition, had hailed Ram as “Imam-e-Hind”. Let Muslims Indians accept Rama as “Imam-e-Hind”—even as Indonesian Muslims accept him as their hero par excellence—and all Hindu-Muslim problems will melt away.’[38] In other words, accept the cultural primacy of Hindus and all are then equal. It follows then that, if every Indian is culturally a Hindu, as the RSS thinks they are, what need is there to declare a Hindu state?

As Sudarshan explained in a May 1998 article, the ‘issue of Hindus vis-a-vis non-Hindus has been dealt with by the late MC Chagla more emphatically than probably any other RSS sympathiser. “In the true sense, we are all Hindus although we may practice different religions. If the distinction (between Hindus and non-Hindus) were to go then there will be no conflict between Hindus and non-Hindus.” (Bhawan’s Journal, August 27-September 9, 1978) … But assimilation presupposes an accommodating philosophy and the realisation of its inherent strength by society which is predominantly Hindu. The expression Hindu has a totally national aspect that takes in its stride the whole gamut of the tradition, culture and other civilisational aspects of social behaviour as evolved on this soil through millennia. Hindu should not be seen in any context other than dharma, which not in the least means religion in the sense of an ecclesiastical order. Dharma is the Hindus’ eternal point of reference.’ This is what, the RSS says, Hedgewar tried to inculcate. The Sangh’s founder, according to Sudarshan, was ‘not in favour of adopting any ready-made ism as the Sangh’s philosophy, no Hedgewarism, and certainly not Hinduism.’[39]

At the heart of these arguments is the belief that India is essentially a secular state because Hindus, in the RSS view, are more secular and pluralist as a society. Equally, it believes that everyone who lives in India is anyway Hindu by culture.

One of Mohan Bhagwat’s predecessors, Rajju Bhaiyya, summed this up when he argued in 1994 that ‘it is erroneous to speak of “India that is Bharat”. Instead, it should be “Bharat that is Hindustan”’. He said, ‘Hindu *rashtra* is not just the Hindu state. The land and the people constitute the country. After hundreds of years of living together, they developed a culture, then became a nation. Thus, three things are essential for a nation—the land, people and